Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Lamentations

Lamentations 1:1–22

Chapter 1 mourns the destruction and desolation of Jerusalem, recognizing that this was God's well-deserved judgment on Israel's sins.

Lamentations 1:2

The lovers were the fertility gods, Baal and Asherah, whom most people in Judah worshiped. who were worshiped by most people in Judah. Her friends were her military allies, notably Egypt, who was not strong enough to defeat Babylon in battle (Jeremiah 37:5–11).

Lamentations 1:3

- The woman in Lamentations 1:1 represents the nation of Judah. The writer describes Judah as a woman who now sits alone and suffers.
- gone into exile: The people of Judah were led away into captivity (forced to leave their land and live in another country). This happened four times:
- In 605 BC, some young men were taken to Babylon (Daniel 1:3–4).
- In 597 BC, King Jehoiachin and many others were taken away (2 Kings 24:12–16; Jeremiah 52:28; Ezekiel 1:2–3).
- In 586 BC, Jerusalem was destroyed and more people were taken into exile (2 Kings 25:5–7, 18–21; Jeremiah 39:5–10; 52:29).
- In 581 BC, another group was taken away after the fall of Jerusalem (Jeremiah 52:30).

Lamentations 1:4

- Zion: In the Psalms and prophetic books, Zion represents the city of Jerusalem. In Lamentations, Zion is a poetic name for the city of Jerusalem. The writer uses this name even when the city lies in ruins (destroyed buildings and broken walls). Hebrews 12:22–24 speaks of the heavenly Zion (see also Revelation 14:1–5).
- The annual festivals in Jerusalem included:
- The Passover
- The Feast of Unleavened Bread
- The Feast of the Firstfruits (also called the Feast of First Harvest)
- The Feast of Harvest (also called Pentecost)
- The Feast of Trumpets
- The Day of Atonement
- The Feast of Tabernacles (also called the Feast of Shelters)

These festivals reminded the people of what God had done for them and helped them renew their covenant (promises between God and his people).

- The priests mainly worked in the temple and its surrounding area. When the temple was in ruins, they had no jobs and no future.

Lamentations 1:5

because of her many transgression: Judah's sins before the Babylonian invasion are described in 2 Kings 21:1–9, 16; 24:3–4 (compare 2 Chronicles 33:1–10, 22–23 and 2 Chronicles 36:11–16). Similarly, a list of Israel's sins before Assyria destroyed it is found in 2 Kings 17:14–23.

Lamentations 1:7

laughing at her downfall: See also Jeremiah 24:9; Ezekiel 22:5; Ezekiel 36:4.

Lamentations 1:8–9

Jerusalem lost everything the people valued, both physical things and spiritual blessings.

Lamentations 1:10

For historical accounts of these events, see 2 Kings 25:8–17; 2 Chronicles 36:13–21; Jeremiah 52:4–30.

Lamentations 1:13

The destruction of Jerusalem by the Babylonians was sudden and overwhelming, like a fire sent from heaven (that is, destruction believed to come from God).

Lamentations 1:14

Because of their sins, the people of Judah were punished. The Babylonians tied them together with ropes and took them away as captives (prisoners of war). They forced them to go into exile (to live in a foreign land).

Lamentations 1:15

- the Virgin Daughter of Judah: God cared for Jerusalem, like a father protecting his daughter. But she continued to sin, and her punishment was horrible.
- Like grapes in a winepress: In ancient times, people crushed grapes by walking on them in a winepress (a large container used to press out juice). The juice flowed out as the grapes were crushed. This image shows how complete and forceful the punishment was.

Isaiah uses this picture to describe judgment in Isaiah 63:3. In Revelation 14:18–20 and 19:15, this image describes God's judgment on the whole earth.

Lamentations 1:19

- I called out to my lovers: Egypt was very interested in Judah because Judah controlled the only good route to the north. However, Egypt abandoned Judah when Babylon attacked Jerusalem (Jeremiah 37:5–11).
- When there was little rain in the fall and spring in Palestine, a summer without rain could ruin crops and cause a food shortage. The food supply also ran out during the long siege of a city, which lasted from January 588 to July 586 BC. Many people starved to death (2 Kings 25:2–3; compare Jeremiah 37:21).

Lamentations 1:20

The leaders and people of Judah had rebelled (Jeremiah 2:17; 5:6, 23) by rejecting the one true God and his commandments. They also resisted the invaders God had sent (2 Kings 24:1, 20; 2 Chronicles 36:13).

Lamentations 1:21

the day You have announced: The poet felt encouraged by the belief that God would establish a day for fair judgment of both oppressors and victims (see Isaiah 13:6, 9; Jeremiah 46:10–12, 27–28; Amos 5:18–20; Obadiah 1:15; 1 Thessalonians 5:2–3; 2 Thessalonians 2:2).

Lamentations 2:1

- heaven: Jerusalem's buildings were beautiful and impressive. Some were covered with precious metals and decorated with jewels. The city was known as the sacred city of the Lord.
- his footstool: Compare 1 Chronicles 28:2; Psalms 99:5; 132:7.

Lamentations 2:1–22

This chapter vividly shows the Lord acting as the one who destroys Jerusalem.

Lamentations 2:3–4

bent His bow: In the past, the Lord had been a powerful warrior for Israel (see Exodus 14:13–15:21; Joshua 23:9–11; Judges 7; 2 Kings 19:32–35). Now he waged war against Jerusalem (see Isaiah 63:10; Ezekiel 24:25).

Lamentations 2:6

A garden shelter was a temporary structure that harvesters set up to provide shade. God had promised to care for his temple forever (1 Kings 9:3), but now it seemed he had abandoned it.

Lamentations 2:7

The temple was destroyed because the priests and the people sinned inside it. Their sins made the temple ceremonially unclean and brought God's judgment on it (see Jeremiah 7:3–15; 26:3–6, 12–13; Ezekiel 24:21).

Lamentations 2:8

Ramparts were stone walls or earth mounds built around a city to protect it from enemy attacks.

Lamentations 2:9

no vision: Daniel and Ezekiel were prophets of the Lord. They had visions while living among the exiles far from Judah (Ezekiel 1:1; Daniel 7:1). This verse, however, speaks about prophets in Jerusalem. These prophets claimed to receive visions from God, but their visions were false.

Lamentations 2:10

- Burlap, also known as sackcloth, was made from goat or camel hair. People often used it for grain sacks or to carry items on pack animals. Poor people wore it as clothing because it was cheap. People in mourning wore it to show their deep sorrow. Its dark color matched their mood, and its roughness matched their discomfort.
- Throwing dust on their heads and clothing signaled to neighbors that a family member had died.

Lamentations 2:13

Who can ever heal you?: There was no one left who could bring healing. The prophets and healers who were trusted by the people had spoken lies and given false hope (Jeremiah 6:13–14).

Lamentations 2:16

Their enemies were glad that Jerusalem was defeated.

Lamentations 2:17

His decree, which He ordained in days of old: God's promises of blessings depended on Israel's obedience to the law (Deuteronomy 8). He had promised to destroy them if they disobeyed it (Leviticus 26).

Lamentations 2:18–19

Repentance and prayer are the proper responses when facing the devastation of God's judgment.

Lamentations 2:20

Jeremiah had warned that the same cannibalism (people eating human flesh during extreme hunger) that happened during the siege of Samaria (2 Kings 6:28–29) would also happen in Jerusalem (Jeremiah 19:9; see also Lamentations 4:10; Ezekiel 5:10; compare Deuteronomy 28:53–57).

Lamentations 2:22

summoned ... for the day of an appointed feast: The poet compares Jerusalem's destruction to a feast where war, famine, wild animals, and sickness consume the wicked in Jerusalem (Deuteronomy 28:15–68; compare Revelation 19:17–21).

Lamentations 3:1–24

The author speaks of the suffering of Judah and Jerusalem as his own.

Lamentations 3:1–66

In this chapter, the author mourns what has happened (Lamentations 3:1–20, 48–54). In this chapter, the author mourns what has happened (Lamentations 3:21–25). He explains how God's people should respond (Lamentations 3:26–47). Finally, he calls out to the Lord in prayer (Lamentations 3:55–66).

Lamentations 3:6–9

Some interpreters understand these verses as a poetic description of Jeremiah's time in a muddy cistern (a deep water pit) before the destruction of Jerusalem (Jeremiah 38:6–13).

Lamentations 3:9

barred my ways ... made my paths crooked: This image describes confusion and trouble. Sin can block a person's path and make life difficult. It can prevent a person or a community from experiencing a hopeful future.

In the Bible, a straight road often represents a good and clear future. Proverbs says that innocent people walk on a straight path (Proverbs 21:8). Isaiah describes the Lord coming on a straight road that his worshipers would prepare (Isaiah 40:3).

Lamentations 3:12

Compare Job 6:4.

Lamentations 3:19

is wormwood and the gall: Wormwood is a plant with a bitter taste. Here, it represents deep emotional pain (Proverbs 5:4; Revelation 8:11).

Gall refers to a poisonous plant. If someone eats it, it causes strong physical pain. Because of this, it became a symbol for extreme suffering and distress (Deuteronomy 29:18; Psalm 69:21).

The author feels trapped, as if there is no way out of his suffering.

Lamentations 3:22

The faithful love of the Lord is the reason the poet begins to recover from deep despair (great sadness). The Lord's love gives him hope again.

This experience is like Jeremiah's rescue from a muddy cistern (Jeremiah 38:6–13) and Jonah's rescue from the belly of the great fish (Jonah 2:2–10). In each case, the Lord saved his servant from death.

Lamentations 3:22–33

God's love and faithfulness never end. Just as God was faithful in judging Jerusalem for their sins, he will be faithful in restoring those who return to him.

Lamentations 3:23

God's faithfulness means that he is completely reliable. We see this in his daily mercies, which are new each day.

He continues to provide a world in which people can live safely.

Lamentations 3:24

The LORD is my portion: The land of Canaan was seen as Israel's inheritance since the time of Moses (Exodus 15:17; Joshua 21:19; 1 Chronicles 28:8; Psalm 47:4). However, the true inheritance for God's people is God himself (see Psalm 16:5–6; Ephesians 1:11; Hebrews 9:15; 1 Peter 1:3–4).

Lamentations 3:26

Those who trust in God's plan can wait patiently and quietly for him to bring deliverance (rescue and restoration).

Lamentations 3:28

sit alone in silence: Humble submission keeps you from speaking and calms your heart.

Lamentations 3:29–30

- In the ancient Near East, lying face down in the dust showed submission (Genesis 17:1–3; Leviticus 9:24; Joshua 7:6; 1 Samuel 5:4; 1 Kings 18:39; 1 Chronicles 21:16; Matthew 17:5–6).
- To turn the other cheek shows a willingness to submit rather than fight back. Jesus likely had this verse in mind when he taught his disciples to accept persecution (Matthew 5:39).

This response shows trust that God rules over all things, even over suffering.

Lamentations 3:31

Compare Psalm 103:8–11.

Lamentations 3:34–36

The people of Judah were doing such things before Jerusalem was destroyed (see Jeremiah 5:26–31; 21:11–14; 23:10–14; Micah 3).

Lamentations 3:37–39

Some disasters have natural causes (Luke 13:1–5). Bad things happen to both good and bad people (Matthew 5:45). No matter what happens, we should give thanks and not complain (1 Thessalonians 5:18).

Lamentations 3:40–42

Repentance is essential for receiving salvation (Isaiah 1:27; Jeremiah 3:22; Ezekiel 3:21).

Lamentations 3:48–66

The author emphasizes how cruel the enemies are and cries out to the Lord for help.

Lamentations 3:52–57

This passage might refer to Jeremiah's experience in the cistern (Jeremiah 37:11–15; 38:1–13).

Lamentations 3:58–66

Jerusalem deserved punishment, but the enemies carried it out with undeserved cruelty. The writer calls upon God to punish them.

Lamentations 3:64–66

This prayer for vengeance is similar to several psalms (see "Prayers for Vengeance" Theme Note).

Lamentations 4:1–22

Although God's people still experience his judgment, they will soon experience restoration.

Lamentations 4:3

like an ostrich: See also Job 39:13–16.

Lamentations 4:7

their appearance like sapphires: (literally like lapis lazuli): Lapis lazuli is a beautiful blue stone. It is soft enough to carve and is often used in decorations and mosaics.

Lamentations 4:8

Skin sticking to bones is symptomatic of the final stages of starvation, just before death.

Lamentations 4:9

Long sieges result in a serious lack of food. Even if people could get to the fields, they would find the crops destroyed or harvested to feed the soldiers.

Lamentations 4:12

The kings of the earth ... could enter the gates of Jerusalem: Since God had saved Jerusalem from Sennacherib of Assyria over a century earlier (2 Kings 19:36–37), the Judeans firmly believed that even the powerful king Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon could not conquer the city.

Lamentations 4:15

It appears that these leaders fled from Jerusalem as refugees to other lands.

Lamentations 4:20

The LORD's anointed ... was captured: This refers to King Zedekiah. He tried to escape from Jerusalem, but the Babylonian army captured him. King Nebuchadnezzar treated him cruelly after his capture (2 Kings 25:4–7; Jeremiah 39:4–7; 52:9–11).

Lamentations 4:21

Uz was a region east of the Jordan River. It extended south to Edom. Uz was the homeland of Job (Job 1:1).

Lamentations 4:21–22

The people of Edom felt safe and took pleasure in Jerusalem's troubles. However, they would also face punishment for their sins (see Obadiah 1; Jeremiah 49:7–22).

Lamentations 4:22

The first return from exile took place in 538 BC. This happened after Cyrus, king of Persia, defeated Babylon (2 Chronicles 36:22–23; Ezra 1:1–4).

Lamentations 5:1–22

This chapter is a sincere prayer asking for restoration (compare Daniel 9:4–19).

Lamentations 5:10

There was a famine in Jerusalem during the siege, and the people ran out of food (2 Kings 25:3; Jeremiah 37:21; 38:9; 52:6).

Lamentations 5:12–17

These terrible things happened because the people had sinned (see Isaiah 24:7–12; Jeremiah 7:24; Jeremiah 13:18; Jeremiah 25:10–11; Amos 8:10).

Lamentations 5:18

patrolled by foxes: Compare Isaiah 13:22; 34:13; Jeremiah 9:11; 10:22; Malachi 1:3.

Lamentations 5:22

unless You have utterly rejected us: The tragedy of the exile caused people to ask whether God would forgive their sin and restore them.

God answered this question through the prophets (Isaiah 40:27–31; 41:8–20). He also answered it by sending Christ, who brought forgiveness and restoration (Matthew 9:2–6; 26:28; Luke 24:47).